

# LI MA

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## PROFESSIONAL SUMMARY

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AI/ML researcher with a Ph.D. and experience in recommender systems, graph learning, retrieval-augmented generation, and generative AI. Research published or accepted at NeurIPS, ICLR, KDD, TKDD, and EACL, with industry research internship experience at Ant Group and Alibaba Group and prior full-time backend development experience. Experienced in machine learning experimentation, data analysis, and software development using Python, Java, SQL, and PyTorch.

## RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

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### Case Western Reserve University

*Visiting Researcher, Computer Science*

Cleveland, OH

06/2026 -- Present

- Conducting research on foundation models, with current interests in causal reasoning and vision-language models.

### Michigan State University

*Visiting Researcher, Computer Science*

East Lansing, MI

08/2023 -- 05/2026

- Evaluated tokenizer designs for generative recommendation and developed a graph-based heuristic method that demonstrated strong empirical performance.
- Co-led the development of Link-MoE, a structure-aware mixture-of-experts framework for graph link prediction; co-first-authored the resulting paper published at NeurIPS 2024.
- Contributed to two RAG-related projects: one on RAG and GraphRAG evaluation and the other on privacy risks; both accepted at KDD 2026.
- Designed an LLM-based multi-agent framework for clinical note assessment and evaluated planner-executor agent systems under adversarial interference; the latter work was published at EACL 2026.

### Shanghai Jiao Tong University

*Doctoral Researcher*

Shanghai, China

09/2019 -- 09/2025

- Conducted doctoral research on graph representation learning and recommender systems, with applications to social recommendation, sequential user modeling, and graph-based route planning.
- Led end-to-end research activities including problem formulation, model development, experimental evaluation, and technical writing.

## INDUSTRY EXPERIENCE

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### Alibaba Group

*Research Intern, Advertising Recommendation Team*

Beijing, China

05/2022 -- 01/2023

- Processed live-stream interaction data and engineered features for recommendation modeling.
- Constructed temporal graphs of user-streamer interactions for user-follow prediction and offline analysis.

### Ant Group

*Research Intern, Graph Platform Team*

Hangzhou, China

04/2021 -- 04/2022

- Developed a task-supervised graph structure learning framework with learnable thresholds to remove noisy edges.
- Demonstrated improvements in node classification and link prediction on heterogeneous and low-homophily graph benchmarks; the resulting first-author work was published in ACM TKDD in 2025.

### Puxin Hengye Technology Co., Ltd.

*Backend Development Engineer, Big Data Innovation Center*

Beijing, China

07/2018 -- 08/2019

- Developed and maintained Java backend services and wrote SQL queries for an internal web platform supporting data access.
- Participated in service deployment, logging, and production issue troubleshooting.

## TECHNICAL SKILLS

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**Programming:** Python, Java, SQL, C/C++, MATLAB

**Machine Learning:** PyTorch, PyTorch Geometric, PyTorch Lightning, Scikit-learn, NumPy, Pandas

**Methods:** Deep Learning, Recommender Systems, Rankings, Generative Recommendation, Graph Neural Networks, Retrieval-Augmented Generation, Large Language Models, Data Analysis, Model Evaluation

**Tools:** Git, Linux, Jupyter, LaTeX

## EDUCATION

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### Shanghai Jiao Tong University

*Ph.D. in Electronic and Information Engineering*

Shanghai, China

09/2019 -- 09/2025

### Xidian University

*M.S. in Computer Science and Technology*

Xi'an, China

09/2015 -- 06/2018

### Shanxi University

*B.E. in Software Engineering*

Taiyuan, China

09/2011 -- 07/2015

## SELECTED PUBLICATIONS (\* indicates equal contribution)

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### First and Co-first Author Publications

- **Li Ma\***, H. Han\*, et al. "Mixture of Link Predictors on Graphs." **NeurIPS**, 2024.
- **Li Ma**, et al. "Building Robust and Trustworthy HGNN Models: A Learnable Threshold Approach for Node Classification." **ACM TKDD**, 2025.
- **Li Ma**, et al. "ExpoEv: Enhancing Social Recommendation Service with Social Exposure and Feature Evolution." **ICWS**, 2023.

### Selected Co-authored Publications

- H. Han, **Li Ma**, et al. "RAG vs. GraphRAG: A Systematic Evaluation and Key Insights." **KDD**, 2026.
- Z. Qi, U. Sahu, **Li Ma**, et al. "Benchmarking Knowledge-Extraction Attack and Defense on Retrieval-Augmented Generation." **KDD**, 2026.
- S. Dong, M. Zhang, P. He, **Li Ma**, et al. "PEAR: Planner-Executor Agent Robustness Benchmark." **EACL**, 2026.
- B. Chen, Y. Kang, **Li Ma**, et al. "Decoupling User Features for User Cold-Start App Recommendation: Static Attributes versus Behavioral Sequences." **WSDM**, 2026.
- H. Han, X. Liu, **Li Ma**, et al. "Structural Fairness-aware Active Learning for Graph Neural Networks." **ICLR**, 2024.

## PREPRINTS AND SUBMISSIONS

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- **Li Ma**, et al. "A Diagnostic Study of Semantic Tokenization for Generative Sequential Recommendation." Under review, 2026.
- H. Han, **Li Ma**, et al. "An Embarrassingly Simple Graph Heuristic Reveals Shortcut-Solvable Benchmarks for Sequential Recommendation." Under review, arXiv:2605.07125, 2026.

## TEACHING EXPERIENCE

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- Teaching Assistant, Data Structures and Algorithms, Shanghai Jiao Tong University: Led recitation sessions, held office hours, and supported an English-taught course with 140+ students.

## HONORS AND AWARDS

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- NeurIPS Scholar Award 2024
- China Undergraduate Mathematical Contest in Modeling, Top 5.6% 2013
- China Graduate Mathematical Contest in Modeling, Top 35% 2020

## PROFESSIONAL SERVICE

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- Reviewer for NeurIPS, KDD, WWW, CIKM, ICDM, ICWS, TKDE, and TKDD.